

Divine Healing Open

prc-divine-healing-open
Spiritual Gifts · Healing · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer; healing is a sovereign mercy, not a guaranteed outcome.

In plain language

James tells a sick believer to call the elders, who pray over him and anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord. The verbs for praying (proseuxasthosan) and anointing (aleipsantes) are commands aimed at God, and the promise that follows says the prayer of faith will save (sosei) the sick and that the Lord will raise him up (egerei). The healing verb has the Lord as its subject, so the help is something God does, not a result the ritual forces. James then commands mutual prayer so that you may be healed (iathete, the passive form of the verb 'to heal', iaomai), where the verb is passive, marking healing as a hoped-for divine result of prayer rather than an automatic outcome. The same writer Paul lists gifts of healings (charismata iamaton, in the plural) among the Spirit's distributions to the church, and Acts records Paul praying for the sick father of Publius and the man being healed (iasato), with more sick people on the island then being healed (etherapeuonto) afterward. The rest of the New Testament fills in the other half of the picture. Paul asked three times for his thorn to be taken away, and the answer was not removal but the words 'my grace is sufficient for you' (arkei soi he charis mou). Paul left his coworker Trophimus sick at Miletus rather than curing him, and he told Timothy to take a little wine for a weak stomach and frequent illnesses. Paul also reminds the Corinthians of the signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou), which gives a reader leaning toward cessation a real foothold by tying signs and powers to the apostolic office. Putting these texts side by side, the words on the page support exactly what the question states. God can heal and sometimes does heal when his people pray, and the language treats that healing as a gift from a sovereign Lord. At the same time the same writers record prayers for healing that were answered with grace rather than cure, and a rhetorical question that expects the answer no when it asks whether all believers have gifts of healings. So the texts give no guarantee that every request for healing will be granted, and they leave room for the live disagreement over whether the apostolic-era concentration of miraculous healing carries forward in the same form, while still affirming the lower-bar claim that healing remains a real mercy available in answer to prayer.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0218	ἀλείφω	aleipho	to anoint	9
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0620	ἀπολείπω	apoleipo	to leave	9
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	
G0714	ἄρκέω	arkeo	be sufficient	8
G0868	ἀφίστημι	aphistēmi	to leave	

G1162	δέησις	deesis	petition	19
G1223	διά	dia	through/because of	
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	82
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G1453	ἐγείρω	egeiro	to arise	143
G1637	ἐλαιον	elaion	olive oil	11
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2323	θεραπεύω	therapeuo	to serve/heal	44
G2386	ἰαμα	iama	healing	3
G2390	ἰάομαι	iaomai	to heal	27
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	86
G4592	σημεῖον	semeion	sign	77
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	108
G5228	ὑπέρ	huper	above/for	
G5229	ὑπεραίρω	hyperairo	be haughty	3
G5486	χάρισμα	charisma	gift	17

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

James 5:14-16 sets healing inside a petition frame addressed to the present church: the sick one calls the elders (presbyterous) who pray (proseuxasthosan, a completed past action used as a command, here a plural imperative meaning 'let them pray') and anoint with oil (aleipsantes elaio, 'having anointed with oil'), and the prayer of faith will save (sosei, 'will save' or 'will rescue') the sick one and the Lord will raise (egerei, 'will raise up', with kyrios, 'Lord', as the explicit subject) him up. James 5:16 then commands mutual prayer that you may be healed (iathete, 'that you may be healed', the passive subjunctive of iaomai, 'to heal'). 1 Corinthians 12:9, 28, 30 lists gifts of healings (charismata iamaton, plural) among the Spirit's ongoing distributions to the church. Acts 28:8-9 narrates Paul praying and laying hands on Publius's father so that the man is healed (iasato, 'he healed') and the rest of the island then keep being cured (etherapeuonto, 'they were being cured', an ongoing or repeated past action). The same canon also limits the claim: Paul prays three times for the thorn and is answered with grace not removal (2 Corinthians 12:8-9), leaves Trophimus sick (2 Timothy 4:20), and prescribes wine for Timothy's frequent illnesses (1 Timothy 5:23). The combined lexical pattern affirms that God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer while withholding any guarantee.

Scripture

Jas.5.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4336 προσεύχομαι, G0218 αλείφω, G1637 ἔλαιον

Reasoning. Is any among you sick ('is anyone sick among you', *asthenei tis en hymin*). Let him call (*proskalesastho*, a completed past action used as a command, here a singular imperative meaning 'let him summon') the elders of the church, and let them pray over him (*proseuxasthosan ep auton*, a completed past action used as a command, plural, meaning 'let them pray over him'), anointing him with oil (*aleipsantes elaio*, 'having anointed with oil') in the name of the Lord. The grammar is petition and ministry by the gathered assembly directed toward a sovereign healer. The verb 'let them pray' (*proseuxasthosan*) plus the prepositional phrase 'over him' (*ep auton*) frames healing as something asked of God on behalf of the sick, not a self-executing technique.

Jas.5.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G1453 ἐγείρω, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Reasoning. And the prayer of faith will save ('will save', *sosei*, a future-tense ongoing simple statement of fact) the sick one (*ton kamnonta*, 'the one who is weary or sick'), and the Lord will raise ('will raise up', *egerei*, future tense with *ho kyrios*, 'the Lord', as explicit subject) him up. The healing is predicated of the Lord as agent, and the following 'and if' (*kan*, 'even if he has committed sins') attaches forgiveness as an 'if-then' clause outcome, showing the verse describes God acting in mercy through prayer rather than asserting an unconditional promise that every prayer secures bodily cure.

Jas.5.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2390 ἰάομαι, G1162 δέησις, G1342 δίκαιος, G1754 ἐνεργέω

Reasoning. Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another ('pray for one another', *euchesthe hyper allelon*, an ongoing simple command) that you may be healed ('that you may be healed', *iathete*, the passive subjunctive of *iaomai*, 'to heal', inside a *hopos* purpose clause meaning 'so that'). The passive plus subjunctive marks healing as a divinely granted result of prayer, not a mechanical consequence. The closing summary, the prayer of a righteous person is powerfully effective (*polu ischyei deesis dikaiou energoumene*, 'the petition of a righteous person being at work has great strength'), locates the power in God's response to answered prayer.

1Cor.12.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5486 χάρισμα, G2386 ἴαμα

Reasoning. To another gifts of healings ('gifts of healings', *charismata iamatōn*) by the one Spirit. Paul lists healing among the gifts (*charismata*) distributed by the Spirit to the assembled body, parallel with faith, prophecy, tongues, and the discernment of spirits. The plural 'of healings' (*iamatōn*) is significant. Healing is plural and various, not a single guaranteed result, and the verb verse 11 supplies (*diairoun idia hekasto kathos bouletai*, 'distributing to each one individually just as he wills') attributes the distribution to the Spirit's own will.

1Cor.12.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2386 ἴαμα, G1411 δύναμις

Reasoning. God placed ('God placed' or 'set', *etheto ho theos*, a completed past action) in the church first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, then powers ('powers' or 'mighty works', *dynameis*), then gifts of healings ('gifts of healings', *charismata iamatōn*). The 'God placed' verb (*etheto*, a completed past action) locates the placement of these gifts in the church (*en te ekklesia*, 'in the assembly'), and the categories sit in a list given to the standing assembly, not bracketed to the apostles alone.

Acts.28.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4336 προσεύχομαι, G2390 ίάομαι

Reasoning. The father of Publius lay sick with fever and dysentery. Paul went in, prayed ('having prayed', proseuxamenos, a completed past action participle), laid hands on him ('having laid his hands on him', epitheis tas cheiras), and healed him ('he healed him', iasato auton, a completed past action middle form of iaomai, 'to heal', with the apostle as the immediate subject and the verb of healing as the explicit outcome). Verse 9 then reports that the rest of the sick on the island came and were being healed ('they were being healed', etherapeuonto, an ongoing or repeated past action, durative). The narrative supplies an instance in which prayer accompanied healing as an actual event.

2Cor.12.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5228 υπέρ, G0868 ἀφίστημι

Reasoning. Concerning this thing I implored the Lord three times ('concerning this I begged the Lord three times', hyper toutou tris ton kyrion parekalesa) that it might depart ('that it might depart' or 'leave', apostei) from me. A repeated, earnest petition for relief is recorded, establishing that the apostle himself prayed for his own healing.

2Cor.12.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0714 ἀρκέω, G1411 δύναμις

Reasoning. The answer is 'my grace is sufficient for you' (arkei soi he charis mou), with 'for power is perfected in weakness' (he gar dynamis en astheneia teleitai). The petition for removal is explicitly not granted. God answers with grace rather than cure, which directly establishes that healing in answer to prayer is not guaranteed even for an apostle.

2Tim.4.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0620 ἀπολείπω

Reasoning. 'I left Trophimus sick at Miletus' (Trophimon de apelipon en Mileto asthenounta). An apostle traveling with healing gifts leaves a companion ill rather than curing him, confirming that bodily healing was not dispensed on demand and was not an automatic outcome.

1Tim.5.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1223 δίδω

Reasoning. Use a little wine for your stomach and your frequent illnesses ('on account of your stomach and your frequent weaknesses', dia ton stomachon kai tas pyknas sou astheneias). The prescription of an ordinary remedy for chronic sickness, given by an apostle to a co-worker, shows that miraculous healing was not assumed to be guaranteed and that natural means coexist with prayer.

2Cor.12.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημείον, G0652 ἀπόστολος

Reasoning. The signs of the apostle ('the signs of the apostle', ta semeia tou apostolou) were worked out among you in all endurance, by signs and wonders and powers ('by signs and wonders and mighty works', semeiois te kai terasin kai dynamesin). The vocabulary marks an authenticating function of miracles tied to apostleship, which a cessationist lens (the view that the miraculous sign gifts ceased after the apostles) treats as a clue that the apostolic-era miraculous concentration does not directly transfer. The same text does not, however, supply a clause forbidding ordinary prayer for healing.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Jas.5.14	1Kgs.17.21	tsk	1

Jas.5.16	Gen.20.17	tsk	1
Jas.5.16	Isa.33.24	tsk	1
2Cor.12.7	Job.2.7	tsk	1
2Cor.12.9	2Cor.12.10	tsk	1
1Tim.5.23	1Tim.3.3	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jas.5.15 · addressed

Read in isolation the prayer of faith will save the sick ('will save', *sosei*) could be pressed into an unconditional guarantee of bodily cure. The grammar resists this. The Lord is the explicit subject of 'will raise up' (*egerei*), making healing his act of mercy, and the surrounding canon (2 Corinthians 12:8-9, 2 Timothy 4:20, 1 Timothy 5:23) shows that earnest prayer for healing is sometimes answered by sustaining grace or left to ordinary means. The verse therefore affirms that God heals in answer to prayer without promising it in every case.

2Cor.12.9 · addressed

This text could be read as denying that God heals through prayer at all. The lexical force is narrower. A specific petition for removal was answered with sufficient grace, which presupposes that the petition was heard and that God could have granted it. It limits the claim of a guarantee but does not contradict that God can and sometimes does heal.

2Cor.12.12 · addressed

'The signs of the apostle' (*ta semeia tou apostolou*) pairs miraculous signs with apostolic credentialing and gives a cessation-leaning reading (the view that miraculous sign gifts ceased after the apostles) a real foothold. The text limits the proposition that all apostolic-era manifestations transfer unchanged. It does not, on the words themselves, cancel the standing James 5 directive to call the elders, pray, and anoint. The proposition under test is the lower-bar claim that God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer, which 2 Corinthians 12:12 does not deny.

1Cor.12.30 · addressed

'Not all have gifts of healings, do they?' (*Me pantes charismata echousin iamaton*) expects the answer no. This forecloses the strong continuationist claim (the view that all the miraculous gifts still operate today) that every believer carries a healing gift, but it presupposes the very category by name. It supports the open proposition (the gift exists in the church) while denying universality.

Concordance traversed

G2390, G4982, G2386, G5486, G4336, G0218, G1637, G1453, G1162, G1342, G1754, G2323, G4592, G0714, G0620, G1411, G5229, G0266

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

James and the Pauline epistles fall outside the 3 John CBGM (a method for tracing manuscript relationships) sample so the variant assessment is shadow only. The apparatus marks visible in the bundle (editorial sigla in James 5:14-16 and 2 Corinthians 12:7-9) touch word order, the connective 'therefore' (*oun*), and pronoun spelling, none of which alter the petition-and-sovereign-outcome pattern that grounds the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. continuationism, cessationism

continuationism: affirms the proposition straightforwardly · James 5:14-16 commands the present church to call elders, pray, anoint, and confess so that the sick may be healed ('that you may be healed', iathete, the passive subjunctive of iaomai, 'to heal'). 1 Corinthians 12:9, 28, 30 names gifts of healings (charismata iamaton) among the Spirit's distributions to the church without a textual time-stamp limiting them. Acts 28:8 narrates 'he healed' (iasato) following prayer and laying on of hands. The lexical pattern is dense and the verbs are present-tense imperatives addressed to the assembly.

cessationism (healing-gift sense): limits the claim but does not contradict it on the words alone · 'The signs of the apostle' (ta semeia tou apostolou) in 2 Corinthians 12:12 couples signs and powers with the apostolic role, and the New Testament records apostolic-era healings concentrated around the foundational mission (Acts 3, 5, 9, 19, 28). The same canon shows Paul's own petitions for healing met with grace not cure (2 Corinthians 12:8-9), Trophimus left sick (2 Timothy 4:20), and Timothy's chronic illness answered with wine (1 Timothy 5:23). On the words alone, the canon supplies no explicit clause canceling the James 5 directive to pray, so a strict cessation of all healing prayer would require an inference the text does not state. The cessationist lens is therefore strongest as a limit on the SCOPE and FUNCTION of miraculous healing, not as a denial of the lower-bar claim that God still hears and sometimes answers prayer for healing.

guaranteed-healing reading: rejected on lexical grounds · A reading that takes James 5:15 'will save' (sosei) as an absolute promise of bodily cure cannot account for the Lord being the explicit agent of 'will raise up' (egerei), the 'and if' (kan, 'even if') clause attached to forgiveness, the rhetorical 'not all' (me pantas) in 1 Corinthians 12:30 that explicitly denies universality of the healing gift, or 2 Corinthians 12:8-9, 2 Timothy 4:20, and 1 Timothy 5:23, where sincere prayer for healing is met with grace, departure, or ordinary remedy.

The two live lenses are continuationism (the view that the miraculous gifts still operate today) and cessationism (the view that they ceased with the apostles). The proposition under test is the lower-bar open claim (God can and sometimes does heal), which sits below the disputed point that divides the two lenses (whether the New Testament healing gifts, charismata, still operate as gifts in the present church). Both lenses can affirm the open claim on its own words. The verdict therefore is robust across the live divide.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition is already balanced (God can and sometimes does heal, healing is a sovereign mercy, not a guaranteed outcome) and does not smuggle in a tradition-specific verdict. It neither asserts guaranteed healing nor cessation. It must be distinguished from the parallel false proposition prc-healing-in-atonement-guaranteed, which would press iaomai ('to heal') in Isaiah 53:5 and 1 Peter 2:24 into a guarantee of bodily cure in the atonement. The present stem makes the weaker open claim, and the lexical data reads cleanly against the plain stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.12.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.12.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.28.8
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2390
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2386
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5486
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0218

syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jas.5.14
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.12.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jas.5.14
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Cor.12.7
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.23

License audit

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